THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK ONE: BEFORE

Chapter 7 — "Presumptive"

Sunday, March 10, 2024 – Friday, April 26, 2024

COLD OPEN — "THE THIRD PEW"

INT. GREATER MOUNT CALVARY BAPTIST CHURCH — SANCTUARY — ATLANTA — MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, MARCH 10, 2024 — 11:02 AM EDT

SUPER: (DAYLIGHT SAVING TIME BEGAN AT 2:00 AM)

A red-brick church built in 1923, the same year as Donohue Entertainment, though no one here would appreciate the comparison. Stained-glass windows of Moses, of Ruth, of a Black Jesus with his arms open. Twelve hundred people in their Sunday best. Ushers in white gloves. Fans from a funeral home that closed in 1988.

Behind the pulpit, in a gold frame, a photograph of the Rev. Dr. Josiah Smilley preaching in 1965, one hand raised.

In the third pew from the front, on the left side, where she has sat every Sunday since 1952: ODESSA SMILLEY (95), in a white church hat with a brim like a satellite dish. On her right, LORRAINE (62). Beside her, SIMONE (36). On the aisle, NEIL (39), in his "BET." pin, which an usher asked him to remove and he politely declined.

On Odessa's left: an empty seat.

The PASTOR, REV. DR. CALVIN HOLLOWAY (70), large, gravel-voiced, Josiah's successor's successor, approaches the pulpit.

REV. HOLLOWAY
Church, we have a guest in the pulpit this morning. Not a preacher. Not a politician. A daughter of this house. She was baptized right there, in that pool, in 1993, by my predecessor, and she screamed so loud the deacons thought the water was boiling.

Laughter ripples through the sanctuary.

REV. HOLLOWAY
She's been in the movies. She's been on the television. She married a man some of y'all have strong opinions about.

(louder laughter)
But this morning she's just Odessa Smilley's granddaughter. Esther, come on up, baby.

From the front pew, ESTHER BULLOCK (31) rises. A simple navy dress. Her grandmother's pearls. No campaign button. No "BET." She walks up the three steps to the pulpit where her grandfather preached for fifty years.

She grips the sides of it. Looks out at twelve hundred faces. Many of them knew her when she was a baby.

And then, from the back of the sanctuary, the double doors open.

Every head turns.

CORNELIUS SMILLEY (65), in a charcoal suit and a burgundy tie, the one his father wore on Sundays, walks down the center aisle. Slowly. He doesn't look left or right. Every person in the church knows exactly who he is and exactly what this means.

He reaches the third pew. Odessa, without looking at him, moves her pocketbook from the empty seat to her lap.

He sits down next to his mother.

Esther, in the pulpit, watches him do it. Her hands tighten on the wood. For a second, she can't speak.

Then she does.

ESTHER
Good morning, Greater Mount Calvary.

CONGREGATION
Good morning!

ESTHER
I'm not here to tell you who to vote for on Tuesday.

(a few knowing chuckles)
I'm serious. My husband would like me to. My campaign manager would like me to. My daddy would like me to tell you the opposite.

(louder laughter; Cornelius doesn't move)
But my grandmother taught me in this building that you don't stand in God's house and campaign. You stand in God's house and tell the truth. So here's the truth.

She looks down at the third pew. At her father.

ESTHER
When I was nineteen years old, I did something my father didn't approve of. I fell in love with somebody he didn't choose. I had two baby girls before I had a wedding ring. And for eleven years, I've been afraid to walk into this church, because I thought the people who loved me here would see me the way he did.

The sanctuary is completely silent.

ESTHER
And then my grandmother called me and said, "Baby, come home and sit in your bedroom upstairs, and on Sunday you come to church, and if anybody looks at you sideways, you send them to me."

(a wave of laughter and "Amen!" — Odessa nods regally)
So I'm home. And here's what I learned in eleven years. My grandfather, whose picture is right behind me, was a great man. And he was a sinner. And both of those things are true. My father is a great man. And he's wrong about my husband. Both of those things are true too.

A murmur. Cornelius's jaw tightens. He stares straight ahead.

ESTHER
And my husband is a good man. He's also thirty-two years old, and he says things on stage that make church mothers clutch their pearls, and he'd stand on this pulpit if Pastor let him.

(laughter)
Both of those things are true.

(beat)
So on Tuesday, vote for whoever you think tells you the truth. And whoever you vote for, come home to this church on Sunday and sit next to the people who voted the other way. Because that's what family is. That's what this church is. That's what this country is supposed to be. You can disagree with somebody all the way to the

ballot box and still pass them the greens at dinner.

She looks directly at her father.

ESTHER
I love you, Daddy. I'm not on your side. But I love you.

A beat. Twelve hundred people hold their breath.

Cornelius doesn't move. Doesn't nod. Doesn't speak.

But his hand, resting on his knee, slowly turns over, palm up. A gesture so small that only three people in the church see it. Odessa sees it. Lorraine sees it. And Esther sees it from the pulpit.

Esther steps back from the microphone. The organist, who has been waiting thirty years to play something this loud, launches into "Blessed Assurance." The congregation rises, singing, and the moment dissolves into music.

In the third pew, Odessa, singing, reaches over without looking and puts her hand in her son's upturned palm. He closes his fingers around it.

Twitter · @ATLchurchgirl

I was AT Greater Mount Calvary this morning. Esther Bullock said "I love you Daddy, I'm not on your side, but I love you" to Cornelius Smilley in front of 1,200 people and I've never heard a church that quiet in my life.

41K Retweets · 288K Likes · 1:14 PM EDT

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

"You can disagree with somebody all the way to the ballot box and still pass them the greens at dinner." ESTHER BULLOCK. PUT IT ON A HAT.

61K Retweets · 410K Likes

ACT ONE — "THE LONG SPRING"

MONTAGE — MARCH 7 TO APRIL 24, 2024 — HEADLINES, POSTS, AND MOMENTS

THE NEW YORK TIMES — FRI, MAR 8

A Combative Biden Delivers Fiery State of the Union, Seeking to Quiet Doubts About His Age

The President jabbed at Republicans, ad-libbed with hecklers, and never mentioned his young Democratic challenger by name.

— SATURDAY, MARCH 9, ATLANTA. Two events, four miles apart. At Morehouse's Forbes Arena, Marc rallies eleven thousand people with Neil Smilley at his side. Across town, at a Black Baptist church in southwest Atlanta, a Biden campaign event, introduced by Cornelius Smilley. Local news splits the screen: father on the left, son on the right, the same jaw.

— TUESDAY, MARCH 12, 11:38 PM EDT. A ballroom at the Georgian Terrace Hotel. Biden's Georgia election-night watch party. Cornelius stands at the back of the room as the ABC projection appears on the screen: "BULLOCK WINS GEORGIA (DEM)." Fifty point four to forty-seven point one. The room goes quiet. A young Biden staffer turns to him with tears in her eyes. He puts a hand on her shoulder. Then he walks out through the kitchen, alone.

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION — WED, MAR 13

Bullock Edges Biden in Georgia as Esther Bullock's Church Speech Reverberates; Cornelius Smilley Loses His Home State

ASSOCIATED PRESS — MAR 12

Trump clinches Republican nomination with wins in Georgia, Mississippi, Washington

Twitter · @NeilSmilleyGA

Georgia. My home. My grandmother's home. My father's home. My sister's home. Tonight it's also Marc's home. To my father: I love you. Pass the greens.

33K Retweets · 211K Likes

POLITICO — WED, MAR 20

Bullock Sweeps Illinois, Ohio, Arizona, Kansas; Biden Holds Florida

The President's Florida win, powered by seniors, is his only bright spot on a night that widens his challenger's lead to nearly 150 delegates.

AP — TUE, MAR 26

Container Ship Strikes Baltimore's Key Bridge, Causing Collapse; Six Workers Presumed Dead

THE NEW YORK TIMES — WED, APR 3

Bullock Wins New York and Wisconsin in Landslides; Biden Takes Only Delaware, His Home State

— MONDAY, APRIL 8, 1:40 PM CDT. Dallas, Texas. A public eclipse-viewing event at Fair Park. Marc, in paper eclipse glasses, standing beside Roy Chapman (66), also in eclipse glasses, both looking up. As totality hits and the sky goes dark in the middle of the afternoon, the crowd of forty thousand screams. Roy, without looking down, mutters:

ROY
Don't make it a whole thing.

MARC
Roy. It's the sun. It IS a whole thing.

— MONDAY, APRIL 15. Manhattan Criminal Court. Jury selection begins in the People of the State of New York v. Donald J. Trump, the first criminal trial of a former American President.

AP — APR 15

Trump's hush money trial begins with jury selection in Manhattan, a historic first

— SATURDAY, APRIL 20, 4:20 PM PDT. The back lawn of the Bakers' house in View Park. LYRIC BAKER, TEN YEARS OLD TODAY, in a gold tiara slightly too big for her, blowing out ten candles plus one to grow on. No marquee this year. No livestream. Just family, a dozen kids from school, BET the dog in a party hat, and Marc in a plain t-shirt. Exactly one year to the minute after "Bet."

LYRIC
I already know my wish.

MARC
Don't say it out loud this time, Lyric-bird. Last time I had to run for President.

LYRIC
(eyes squeezed shut, whispering)
I wish he wins.

She blows. Ten candles. All out.

AP — SAT, APR 20

House Passes $95 Billion Aid Package for Ukraine, Israel, Taiwan After Months of Delay

Instagram · @harmonybaker

[Photo: Lyric with ten candles; in the background, Marc holding BET in a party hat] Caption: 10. One year ago today, at 4:20, this girl asked a question. Today at 4:20 she made the same wish. We'll see.

14.1M likes

— TUESDAY, APRIL 23, 10:51 PM EDT. Scranton, Pennsylvania. A union hall on the edge of the city. Biden's birthplace. ABC projects: "BULLOCK WINS PENNSYLVANIA (DEM)." Fifty point two to forty-eight point three. In the hall, a few hundred Bullock volunteers, mostly young, cheer. In the back, an older Irish-American union electrician in a "SCRANTON JOE" t-shirt sits on a folding chair, not cheering. A VOLUNTEER (22) sits down next to him.

VOLUNTEER
You okay, sir?

ELECTRICIAN (70s)
I voted for Joe in 1972. For Senate. When he was twenty-nine and everybody said he was too young.

(beat)
Funny how that goes.

THE PHILADELPHIA INQUIRER — WED, APR 24

Bullock Wins Pennsylvania, Biden's Birth State; Delegate Math Now Nearly Impossible for the President

AXIOS — WED, APR 24

By the numbers: Bullock leads by ~192 pledged delegates. Biden would need ~64% of all remaining delegates.

POLITICO PLAYBOOK — THU, APR 25

Wilmington goes quiet

Senior Democrats begin placing calls. "Joe, I love you, but..."

ACT TWO — "THURSDAY"

INT. BULLOCK FOR AMERICA HQ — CENTURY CITY — WAR ROOM — MORNING

SUPER: THURSDAY, APRIL 25, 2024 — 9:12 AM PDT / 12:12 PM EDT

The glass-walled corner office. Patti Grove (60), Elxa (33), Grace (30: she turned thirty on April 12 and has refused to discuss it), Amond (32), Arianna (31). On the TVs: the Supreme Court, where at this moment justices are hearing oral arguments in Trump v. United States, the presidential immunity case. On another screen, the Manhattan courthouse, the hush-money trial in its second week.

On a third screen, Wilmington: the outside of Biden campaign headquarters. Reporters on the sidewalk. Nothing happening. That's the story.

PATTI
Nothing. No schedule. No events. No surrogates booked on any Sunday show. The President's public schedule for today has one item: "The President receives the President's Daily Brief." That's it.

ELXA
That's not nothing.

PATTI
That's not nothing. That's a man in a room making a decision.

Grace's phone buzzes. She looks at it. Her face changes.

GRACE
Politico. Breaking. "Sources: Biden to address the nation from the Oval Office tonight at 8 PM Eastern."

Silence. Everyone in the room understands.

AMOND
Eight Eastern is five here.

ELXA
Where's Marc?

PATTI
Home. Esther made him take the morning off. First morning off in three months. He's making pancakes for the girls before school.

ELXA
Somebody call him.

PATTI
No.

Everyone turns.

PATTI
Nobody calls him. Nobody texts him. Nobody tells him what this is. He's thirty-two years old, he's making pancakes for his daughters, and in eight hours his life is going to change forever. Let him have the pancakes.

Elxa looks at Patti for a long moment. Then nods.

ELXA
I'll drive over at three. I'll tell him myself.

ARIANNA
(quietly)
What if it's not that? What if he's announcing something else? A health thing. A foreign policy thing.

PATTI
Honey, a President doesn't book the Oval Office at eight o'clock on a Thursday, one year to the day after he announced his campaign, to talk about foreign policy.

She looks at the calendar on the wall. "APRIL 25." Circled in red.

PATTI
One year ago today he launched. "Let's finish the job." Tonight he finishes it.

INT. SUNRISE HILL — KITCHEN — MORNING

SUPER: 9:20 AM PDT

Sunlight. Pancakes shaped like the letters of the alphabet, because Victoria requested "a whole alphabet, in order, or I'm not going to school."

Marc (32), in sweats, at the griddle. Esther (31) at the island with coffee. EMMA and VICTORIA (11, twelve in fifteen days), in Paul Revere Middle School hoodies, eating. A Secret Service agent at the kitchen door eating a "Q."

On the TV, muted: the Supreme Court. Esther glances at her phone. Her face goes still for one second. She turns the phone face-down.

MARC
(not looking up from the griddle)
What?

ESTHER
Nothing.

MARC
That was a "something" nothing.

ESTHER
It was a "make the alphabet" nothing.

He looks at her. She holds his gaze. Shakes her head, very slightly: not in front of the girls.

He understands. Flips a pancake. An "X."

MARC
X marks the spot.

VICTORIA
That's a cheat letter. Nobody eats X.

EMMA
Xylophone. Xenophobia. Xerox.

VICTORIA
Nobody EATS those.

MARC
Okay, two more letters and then school. Y and Z. Yes and Zed.

EMMA
Zed is British.

MARC
I'm a uniter.

INT. BIDEN FOR PRESIDENT HQ — WILMINGTON, DELAWARE — CORNELIUS'S OFFICE — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 3:41 PM EDT

A borrowed office in a building that, a year ago, was full of energy. Today it's half-empty. Staffers in the hallway with red eyes. Someone is boxing up a "BIDEN-HARRIS 2024" banner that was never unrolled.

Cornelius (65) at a borrowed desk. His overnight bag. On the desk, a printout of a delegate spreadsheet with "64%" circled in red.

A SENIOR BIDEN CAMPAIGN OFFICIAL (50s) in the doorway. A longtime Biden loyalist. Exhausted.

SENIOR BIDEN OFFICIAL
Cornelius. He wants you to know. Before the cameras. He's going to do it tonight.

Cornelius nods slowly. He knew.

CORNELIUS
How is he?

SENIOR BIDEN OFFICIAL
At peace, I think. More than the rest of us. He said, and this is a quote, "Fifty years. Somebody gave me a chance when I was twenty-nine. It's that kid's turn."

Cornelius looks down at his hands.

SENIOR BIDEN OFFICIAL
He also said to tell you thank you for South Carolina. And North Carolina. He said nobody's ever held a firewall like you held it. He said you'd have held it in Georgia if it wasn't your own daughter on the other side.

Cornelius's head comes up sharply.

CORNELIUS
He said that?

SENIOR BIDEN OFFICIAL
He said, "Tell Cornelius, nobody wins a fight against their own kid. And nobody should."

A very long silence. The official leaves.

Cornelius reaches into his breast pocket. Takes out the twins' card, soft and worn now from two months of being carried. He doesn't read it. He knows it by heart. He just holds it.

EXT. SUNRISE HILL — BACK TERRACE — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 3:12 PM PDT / 6:12 PM EDT

Marc on a lounge chair by the pool, finally reading a book for the first time in months. He has gotten through four pages.

Elxa (33) comes through the French doors. She's still in her work clothes. She sits on the end of his lounge chair. She doesn't say anything.

MARC
You drove over.

ELXA
I drove over.

MARC
Elxa, you never drive over. You call. You text. You send Grace. You don't drive over.

ELXA
The President is addressing the nation from the Oval Office tonight at eight Eastern. Five o'clock here.

Marc sets the book down on his chest. Stares at her.

MARC
...About what?

ELXA
You know about what.

He looks out at the city. At the hills. At the sky.

MARC
He could be staying in. He could be doing a "the fight goes on" thing.

ELXA
He could be.

MARC
You don't think so.

ELXA
Patti says nobody books the Oval to say they're staying in. You go to a rally for that. You go to the Oval to say goodbye.

Marc sits with that. A long time. Then he gets up and walks to the edge of the terrace. Looks out over Los Angeles, the way he did on New Year's Eve, sixteen months ago, with a fake mustache on.

MARC
(quietly)
I don't want him to lose like this.

ELXA
Marc —

MARC
I mean it. I wanted to win. I wanted to beat him. But not like this. Not him sitting in that office having to say it out loud. He's eighty-one. He's done this for fifty years. He buried a wife and a daughter and a son and he kept going. And I'm a guy who said "Bet" at a birthday party.

ELXA
You're a guy who won twenty-nine contests, including his birth state.

MARC
I know. That's what makes it worse.

Elxa stands. Goes to him. Puts her arm around her little brother's shoulders. She's two inches shorter than him. She has never once acted like it.

ELXA
Listen to me. You're allowed to be sad for him. That's what makes you who you are. But at five o'clock, you're going to sit in that family room with your wife and your daughters, and you're going to watch a man end fifty years of service with dignity, and you're going to honor it. And then you're going to pick up the phone when it rings.

MARC
What phone?

ELXA
The one that's going to ring.

ACT THREE — "THE OVAL OFFICE"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL REPORT — NEW YORK — NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, APRIL 25, 2024 — 7:56 PM EDT / 4:56 PM PDT

The ABC News Special Report graphic. The urgent music. David Muir (50) at the anchor desk, George Stephanopoulos (63) beside him.

DAVID MUIR
Good evening. In a few moments, President Biden will address the nation from the Oval Office. The White House has not said what he will discuss. But it comes two days after his loss in the Pennsylvania primary, in his birth state, and with Marc-Anthony Bullock holding a lead of nearly two hundred pledged delegates that most analysts believe the President cannot overcome.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And it comes exactly one year to the day after President Biden launched his re-election campaign. April twenty-fifth, 2023.

DAVID MUIR
We'll take you there live.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS SPECIAL REPORT — PRESIDENT BIDEN TO ADDRESS THE NATION

INTERCUT — LOCATIONS — 7:58 PM EDT / 4:58 PM PDT

— SUNRISE HILL, FAMILY ROOM. Marc and Esther on the couch, hands clasped. Emma and Victoria cross-legged on the floor in front of them. Elxa standing in the doorway, as always. Grace on the arm of the couch. Amond and Harmony, with LYRIC (10) between them, on the loveseat. BET the dog under Lyric's feet. Nobody is speaking.

— DONOHUE ESTATE, LIBRARY. Victor (77), Joan (76), Natasha (52), Robert (55). Joan holds Victor's hand.

— SMILLEY HOUSE, PARLOR, ATLANTA. Odessa (95). Lorraine (62). Simone (36). Neil (40; he turned forty on March 22, and his father called him that morning, the first call in three weeks). The family Bible open on Odessa's lap. She isn't reading it. She just likes having it there.

— BIDEN HQ, WILMINGTON. Cornelius alone in his borrowed office, standing, watching a small TV on a filing cabinet.

— CHAPMAN HOUSE, HOUSTON. Roy (66) in his recliner, reading glasses on. Tyler (32) on the couch.

— A SOUNDSTAGE, LOCATION WITHHELD. Between setups, a figure in half a suit of violet-and-green armor sits in a director's chair marked "C.R.," watching on a phone propped against a water bottle. His helmet is on the floor beside him.

— BULLOCK HQ, CENTURY CITY. Patti Grove alone in the war room. The rest of the staff, three hundred people, gathered in the bullpen around the big screens. Total silence on four floors.

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — NIGHT (BROADCAST)

SUPER: 8:00 PM EDT

The Resolute Desk. The flags. Family photographs on the credenza behind him. PRESIDENT JOE BIDEN (81), in a navy suit and blue tie, hands folded on the desk, looks into the camera. His voice is steady, quiet, the familiar Scranton cadence worn smooth by fifty years.

PRESIDENT BIDEN
My fellow Americans. Good evening.

(beat)
A year ago today, I asked you for the chance to finish the job. And for the last year, I've campaigned across this country to make that case. Tonight I want to talk with you about what comes next, for our party and for our country.

(beat)
Folks, I've been in public life for more than fifty years. I've won some and lost some. And I've always believed one thing: in this democracy, the voters decide. Not the politicians. Not the pundits. The voters.

(beat)
And the voters have spoken. In Michigan, in California, in Texas, in Georgia, in my home state of Pennsylvania. They've chosen a different path for our party. And I respect that.

In Sunrise Hill, Esther's grip tightens on Marc's hand. Marc doesn't breathe.

PRESIDENT BIDEN
So tonight, I am ending my campaign for re-election. I will serve out the remainder of my term as your President, and I'll give it everything I've got, every single day, until noon on January 20th.

In the Smilley parlor, Odessa closes her eyes. Lorraine puts a hand over her mouth.

In Wilmington, Cornelius sits down slowly on the edge of the desk.

PRESIDENT BIDEN
I want to say something to the young man who beat me.

(beat, the ghost of a smile)
When I was elected to the United States Senate, I was twenty-nine years old. Everybody said I was too young. Somebody gave me a chance anyway. And I've spent fifty years trying to be worthy of it.

(beat)
Marc, you've earned your chance. I'm going to help you make the most of it. And I'd ask the Congress, Democrats and Republicans, to take up the amendment that would let the American people decide whether a man your age can serve. Let the voters decide. That's the whole idea.

In Sunrise Hill, Marc puts his free hand over his eyes.

PRESIDENT BIDEN
To the folks who voted for me in South Carolina, in North Carolina, in Florida, in Alabama, the church mothers, the union guys, the folks who've been with me since the beginning: thank you. I love you. Now it's time to bring this party together. Our differences are nothing compared to what's at stake in November.

(beat)
I've always said I see myself as a bridge to a new generation of leaders. Well, folks, the bridge has done its job. It's time to cross.

(beat)
God bless you all. And may God protect our troops.

He holds the camera's gaze for a moment longer. Then the broadcast cuts to the exterior of the White House at night, the flag lit on the roof.

SUPER: 8:11 PM EDT — PRESIDENT BIDEN ENDS HIS RE-ELECTION CAMPAIGN

INT. SUNRISE HILL — FAMILY ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 5:11 PM PDT

No one moves.

Then Lyric, ten years old, very quietly, to no one in particular:

LYRIC
...Did my wish come true?

Harmony pulls her into her lap. Amond looks at Marc across the room. Marc is staring at the screen with tears running down his face. He doesn't wipe them away.

VICTORIA
Daddy, why are you crying? You won.

Marc gets down off the couch onto the floor with his daughters. Puts an arm around each of them.

MARC
Because sometimes when you win, somebody else has to lose, and they're a good person, and they did everything right for a long time. And it's sad. Both things at once.

EMMA
Both things are true.

MARC
Both things are true.

Esther kneels down next to them. Kisses Marc on the temple.

And then, on the coffee table, Marc's phone rings.

Not a ring he's heard before. A number with no caller ID. Just: "UNKNOWN."

Everyone in the room looks at it. Elxa, in the doorway, very quietly:

ELXA
That's the phone.

Marc stares at it. Two rings. Three.

ESTHER
Answer it, baby.

He picks it up.

MARC
...Hello?

WHITE HOUSE OPERATOR (V.O.)
Mr. Bullock, this is the White House operator. Please hold for the President.

Marc stands up. He doesn't know why. He just does. Esther stands with him. The twins look up at him. Lyric watches with enormous eyes.

A click.

We stay on Marc's face. We hear only his side.

MARC
Mr. President.

(listens)
...Thank you, sir.

(listens; a choked laugh)
Yes, sir. Yes, I'm crying. My eleven-year-old just asked me why.

(listens)
...She's right here. She's eleven. She keeps a spreadsheet.

(listens, laughing through tears)
I'll tell her.

(listens; serious now)
Sir, I want you to know something. I meant what I said in Atlanta. You were the "too young" guy once. Everything I am in this race, I'm standing on what you built. I'm not going to forget that. Ever.

(listens for a long time)
Yes, sir. Whenever you want. I'll be there.

(listens)
...And sir? Please tell the First Lady thank you. For everything. For fifty years.

(listens)
Thank you, Mr. President. God bless you.

He lowers the phone. Stares at it.

ESTHER
What did he say?

MARC
He said...

(a laugh, wiping his face)
He said "kid, you ran one hell of a race." He said he wants me at the White House next week. He said he's going to campaign for me in Pennsylvania and Michigan and anywhere I want. And he said...

He looks down at Emma.

MARC
He said to tell the girl with the spreadsheet that he used to keep one too. In 1972. On a legal pad.

Emma's mouth falls open.

EMMA
The PRESIDENT said that? About ME?

MARC
About you, baby.

Emma bursts into tears. Victoria hugs her. Lyric, not entirely sure what's happening but certain it's important, hugs both of them. BET the dog barks.

ACT FOUR — "PRESUMPTIVE"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL REPORT — NIGHT

SUPER: 8:14 PM EDT

DAVID MUIR
An extraordinary moment in American political history. President Joe Biden, eighty-one years old, has ended his campaign for re-election. He is the first sitting President to abandon a re-election bid since Lyndon Johnson, who announced his decision from the Oval Office on March thirty-first, 1968.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And with the President's withdrawal, Marc-Anthony Bullock, thirty-two years old, becomes the presumptive Democratic nominee for President of the United States.

CHYRON: BIDEN ENDS CAMPAIGN — MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK BECOMES PRESUMPTIVE DEMOCRATIC NOMINEE

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Let's be precise about what that means. Bullock has about seventeen hundred and eighteen pledged delegates. He needs nineteen sixty-eight to formally clinch. With no major opponent left, he's expected to cross that line in the next few weeks, most likely on May fourteenth, when Maryland, Nebraska, and West Virginia vote. And the President's delegates are not bound to him after he withdraws. Most are expected to back Bullock at the convention.

DAVID MUIR
And if he wins in November, he would be...

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
He'd be the youngest President in American history by nearly a decade. Theodore Roosevelt was forty-two. John F. Kennedy was forty-three when elected. And of course, under current law, he couldn't serve until January 2027, unless the Constitution is amended. Which is exactly what President Biden just asked Congress to do.

INT. BIDEN HQ — WILMINGTON — CORNELIUS'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 8:16 PM EDT

Cornelius sits on the edge of the desk, the TV still on. He hasn't moved since "I am ending my campaign."

His phone buzzes. WES THORNTON. He looks at it. Lets it ring out.

It buzzes again immediately. A text.

> **WES THORNTON — 8:16 PM EDT**
>
> Well. Now it's Trump vs. your son-in-law. Clean fight. You still have the rest of that file?

Cornelius reads it. His thumb hovers over the keyboard.

He looks at the TV: the White House at night. "Nobody wins a fight against their own kid. And nobody should."

He types.

> **CORNELIUS — 8:19 PM EDT**
>
> Lose my number, Mr. Thornton.

He looks at it. Hits send. Then, for good measure, he blocks the number.

He sits very still for a moment, as if he has just set down something enormously heavy and doesn't quite trust his arms to work without it.

Then he picks up his overnight bag. Turns off the TV. Walks out of the borrowed office, down the half-empty hallway, past the staffer boxing up the "BIDEN-HARRIS 2024" banner. He stops. Puts a hand on her shoulder.

CORNELIUS
Thank you for your service, young lady. You did good work. The President's proud of you.

BIDEN STAFFER (20s)
(crying)
What happens now, Mr. Smilley?

Cornelius looks at her for a long moment.

CORNELIUS
Now? Now the young people take over.

(beat)
God help us all.

And, very slightly, he smiles.

EXT. SUNRISE HILL — UPPER TERRACE — DUSK

SUPER: 6:20 PM PDT / 9:20 PM EDT

The same terrace. The same railing. Helicopters again, three of them now. On Bellagio Road below, the crowd is bigger than April 20 last year: thousands. Candles. Signs. "BET." "THANK YOU JOE." "LET'S FIX IT." Somebody is playing "Ain't No Mountain High Enough" on a Bluetooth speaker.

Marc stands at the railing in a navy suit. Grace holds a phone on a tripod, ready to go live. Patti Grove, who drove from Century City in fourteen minutes, a personal record, stands just off camera with her arms crossed.

Marc turns to Esther, who is standing beside him.

MARC
Esther.

ESTHER
Yes?

MARC
I'm about to go live and accept the presumptive Democratic nomination for President of the United States. I'm telling you first.

Esther stares at him. Then she laughs, a big, surprised, full-hearted laugh.

ESTHER
You remembered.

MARC
You said never again without telling you first. I'm telling you first.

ESTHER
Marc, I'm standing right here. I watched it happen. I was on the call.

MARC
Rules are rules.

PATTI
Says the man who breaks every single one.

MARC
Not hers.

Esther kisses him. Then steps back and nods.

ESTHER
Go.

Grace hits LIVE. The counter: 2 million. 8 million. 19 million. 31 million.

MARC
(to camera)
Hi, everybody.

(beat)
A little over an hour ago, President Biden ended his campaign. I want to start by saying thank you to him. Not as a formality. For real.

(beat)
Fifty years. He served this country for fifty years. He lost his first wife and his baby daughter one week before Christmas, weeks after he was elected to the Senate, and he took the oath anyway, at his sons' hospital bedside. He lost his son Beau. And he kept going. Every time. He kept going. Tonight he did the hardest thing a person in power can do. He let go. With grace. Because he believes the voters decide. I'll never forget it. And I'll never forget the phone call he just made to me, or the thing he said to my daughter.

(beat)
To everybody who voted for him: I know how you feel tonight. I'd feel the same way. I'm not asking you to forget him. I'm asking you to let me earn you. I'm coming

to your churches and your union halls and your senior centers. Not to ask for anything. To listen. And to say thank you.

Below, the crowd on Bellagio Road, watching on their phones, applauds.

MARC
A year and five days ago, a nine-year-old asked me why I couldn't fix it. Tonight, I'm the presumptive Democratic nominee for President of the United States. I'm thirty-two years old. I know. I KNOW.

(a small smile)
And I know the Constitution says thirty-five. The President of the United States just asked Congress to let the voters decide. I'm asking too. Two-thirds of the House. Two-thirds of the Senate. Thirty-eight states. Let the voters decide.

(beat)
And to the other side. To President Trump. To the Republicans watching. I'm not your enemy. I'm your opponent. And I'm going to beat you fair and square, and then I'm going to invite you to dinner.

(beat)
Okay. That's it. I love you. I'm going to go hug my kids now.

He reaches toward the phone to end the live. Stops. Leans back in.

MARC
Oh. And one more thing.

(beat)
November...

From the road below, thousands of people. From thirty-one million phones. From the family room, where the twins and Lyric are standing on the couch, of course:

EVERYONE
BET.

He ends the live.

SUPER: 6:27 PM PDT — MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK ACCEPTS PRESUMPTIVE NOMINATION — 31.4 MILLION LIVE VIEWERS

ACT FIVE — "WHAT IT MEANS"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: 10:02 PM EDT

A wider set. Muir and George joined by the ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR and two analysts: a former Republican congresswoman, REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE (61, fictional, R-Ohio), and a Democratic strategist and historian of the Black vote, DR. MALCOLM REESE (55, fictional, Howard University).

DAVID MUIR
We've had two hours to absorb it. Let's talk about what it means. For the Democratic Party. For the country. Dr. Reese.

DR. MALCOLM REESE
David, what happened tonight is the largest generational transfer of power inside a major American party since at least 1960. Maybe ever. Think about it: the outgoing standard-bearer was born during World War Two. The incoming one was born the month the Bills lost Super Bowl Twenty-Six. There are fifty years between them, and that's more than a gap in age. It's a different country. Different technology, different economy, different relationship to race and family and media.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And the coalition?

DR. MALCOLM REESE
That's the most fascinating part. Bullock won by assembling a coalition nobody has assembled before. Young voters of every race, by enormous margins. Union households in the Midwest. Arab-American voters in Michigan who'd given up on the party. Latino voters in Nevada and Arizona. And, remarkably, a meaningful number of Republicans and independents crossing over in open-primary states like Texas and Virginia.

DAVID MUIR
But the President held older Black voters.

DR. MALCOLM REESE
Overwhelmingly, until the end. And that's the challenge, and the opportunity. Black voters over fifty are the backbone of the Democratic Party. They stayed with Biden in the South out of loyalty, out of history, out of trust earned over decades. Bullock is the second Black presumptive nominee in history, but he did NOT win older Black voters in the primary. He has to earn them now. And frankly, so far, he's said all the right things. "I'm coming to your churches to listen." That's the right instinct.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Congresswoman Kastle. The view from the right.

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
George, I've been a Republican for forty years, and I'll be honest with you: tonight, a lot of my party's strategists are scared. Not because of his policies. Half of what he says sounds like a Republican on a good day. Strong defense. Family. Business. Lower taxes, he says eliminate them, which is crazy, but it's crazy in a direction my voters like. They're scared because Trump has spent nine years running against "the establishment," and now the establishment has just stepped aside for a thirty-two-year-old who talks like a stand-up comic and gives money to food banks in Midland, Texas.

DAVID MUIR
Can Trump beat him?

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
Absolutely. Don't underestimate Donald Trump. Nobody who has ever underestimated him has enjoyed it. He'll go after the age. He'll go after the money: richest man in history, out of touch. The family company that owns the network we're sitting in right now. The comedy clips. The rule-breaking, the "Marc Moves," he'll call it lawlessness. And the amendment. Trump will say, "They're rewriting the Constitution for a Hollywood kid." That's a powerful message with a lot of voters.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Which brings us to the amendment.

The Political Director pulls up a graphic: "THE AGE AMENDMENT — STATUS."

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Here's where it stands tonight. Two hundred and thirty-one co-sponsors in the House, including thirty-eight Republicans. It needs two hundred and ninety votes for two-thirds. In the Senate it needs sixty-seven. And then thirty-eight state legislatures. Before tonight, almost nobody thought it was possible. After tonight, with the sitting President of the United States personally calling on Congress, it moves from "impossible" to "very, very difficult."

DAVID MUIR
And if it fails?

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Then, if Bullock wins in November, under the Twentieth Amendment, his Vice President-elect would act as President from January twentieth, 2025 until January fifth, 2027, his thirty-fifth birthday. Which means his running mate may be the most consequential vice-presidential choice in the history of the Republic.

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
And if he picks someone under thirty-five too —

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Then if the amendment fails, neither one can serve, and under the Presidential Succession Act, the Speaker of the House becomes Acting President. Whoever that is after November.

A pause on the set.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
So the House races just became presidential races.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
In a way nobody has ever seen.

DAVID MUIR
Dr. Reese, last word. The future of the Democratic Party.

DR. MALCOLM REESE
David, for fifty years the Democratic Party has been run by people who remember the civil rights movement firsthand. Tonight it passed to someone who learned about it in a history class and on a Donohue Channel special. That's not good or bad. It's just true. The question is whether he can carry what they built without dropping it. Whether he can be young and still honor the old. If he can, the Democratic Party might own the next thirty years. If he can't, it's going to split down the middle by age.

(beat)
Either way, the party that existed this morning doesn't exist anymore.

MONTAGE — REACTIONS — APRIL 25–26, 2024

— 8:47 PM EDT. A statement from former President Barack Obama, released on social media, praising President Biden's half-century of service and his selfless decision, and congratulating Bullock on a campaign that brought millions of new voices into the democratic process.

— 9:05 PM EDT. A statement from the Trump campaign, from a spokesperson: Biden "was forced out by his own party," and Bullock is "a Hollywood billionaire who isn't even old enough to be President, and the Democrats want to change the Constitution to

install him."

— 9:30 PM EDT. House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (53), on the Capitol steps, calling Biden a giant of the Democratic Party and saying House Democrats will work with any Republican willing to move the age amendment.

— 9:41 PM EDT. Senate Majority Leader Chuck Schumer (73), in a written statement, thanking Biden and pledging his support for the party's nominee.

— 10:15 PM EDT. Vice President Kamala Harris (59), in a short statement, praising the President's courage and lifetime of service and pledging her support to the nominee.

— 11:08 PM EDT. Rep. James Clyburn (83) of South Carolina, the man whose 2020 endorsement resurrected Biden's campaign, tells reporters in a Capitol hallway that he plans to meet with Bullock soon, in South Carolina, at his church. Bullock says he wants to listen. Clyburn says he intends to find out how well.

Twitter · #ThankYouJoe

Trending #1 Worldwide · 5.1M Tweets

Twitter · #PresidentialNominee

Trending #2 in United States · 2.8M Tweets

Twitter · #Bet

Trending #3 Worldwide · 2.2M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

WE DID IT. WE ACTUALLY DID IT. A YEAR AND FIVE DAYS AFTER A BIRTHDAY PARTY. AND JOE BIDEN CALLED EMMA "THE GIRL WITH THE SPREADSHEET" AND TOLD HER HE KEPT ONE TOO IN 1972. I'M SOBBING AT A RED LIGHT.

312K Retweets · 2.1M Likes

Twitter · @PattiGrove

29 contests. 1,718 delegates. One birthday party. I've run four presidential campaigns. This is the first one where the candidate cried for his opponent on the phone with the President. I'm going to sleep for a week. (I'm not. We have a general election.)

88K Retweets · 702K Likes

Twitter · @gramma.flies.free

I'm 82. I told y'all I'd crawl to the polls. Looks like I'll be crawling in November now. Thank you Joe. Thank you Marc. That boy got me home.

201K Retweets · 1.6M Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

Joe Biden handled that like a gentleman. I didn't vote for him. I respect him. That's my post.

401K Retweets · 3.1M Likes

TikTok · @scranton.joe.forever

[Video: the old electrician from the Scranton union hall, at his kitchen table, watching Biden's address, saluting the TV] "I voted for him at 29. I'm voting for the kid at 32. That's how it's supposed to work."

18.2M views · 4.4M likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

The sitting President just asked Congress to rewrite Article II for his 32-year-old replacement. I've never been so disappointed in Joe Biden, and I never voted for him.

6,402 Retweets · 28K Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ArizonaGrandpa: "Carl, the President literally said 'let the voters decide.' That's the most democratic thing anyone has ever said about the Constitution. Go outside."

61K Likes

Twitter · @jaxonwilde

The Democrats just pushed out a sitting President to crown a Hollywood nepo baby. If you don't see the danger, you're not paying attention. Wilde Card emergency episode tonight.

4,108 Retweets · 13K Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

@jaxonwilde Jaxon. Nobody pushed anybody. 31 states voted. One man let go with grace. You've been on a podcast for a year and you still can't let go of 2005.

211K Retweets · 1.8M Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

I'm a Republican. I didn't vote for either of them. Tonight I watched one man end fifty years with dignity and the other cry because he did. I'm sitting in my grandmother's parlor and she just said "now that's how you do it" to the television. I agree with her.

102K Retweets · 891K Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"MEGATHREAD: President Biden ends re-election campaign in Oval Office address; Marc-Anthony Bullock becomes presumptive Democratic nominee"

412K upvotes · 88,201 comments · Top comment: "The 'bridge' line. He's been saying it since 2020. He meant it. Whatever you think of his presidency, that was a man keeping his word."

Reddit · r/politics — reply

"and then Bullock went live and the first thing he did was tell his wife he was about to do it. Because she made him promise last year. Even after she watched the whole thing happen. That's the most wholesome thing I've ever seen a presidential candidate do."

ASSOCIATED PRESS — 8:11 PM EDT

Biden ends reelection campaign, clearing path for 32-year-old Marc-Anthony Bullock to become Democratic nominee

THE NEW YORK TIMES

Biden Bows Out, Passing the Torch to a New Generation: 'The Bridge Has Done Its Job'

In an Oval Office address one year after launching his campaign, the President urged Congress to let voters decide whether his 32-year-old successor can serve.

THE WASHINGTON POST

First Sitting President Since LBJ to Abandon Reelection Bid; Bullock Becomes Presumptive Nominee

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Bullock's Rise Rewrites Democratic Politics; Markets Rally on Clarity, Donohue Shares Hit Record

POLITICO

'Kid, you ran one hell of a race': Inside the call between Biden and Bullock

AXIOS

What's next: the age amendment, the VP pick, and the most important House races in history

FIVETHIRTYEIGHT

Bullock vs. Trump: our first general-election polling average shows the Democrat ahead by double digits, with one enormous constitutional asterisk

FOX NEWS

Biden pushed aside as Democrats crown 32-year-old Hollywood billionaire; Trump campaign: 'They want to rewrite the Constitution'

THE PHILADELPHIA INQUIRER

Scranton's Son Steps Aside

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION

Cornelius Smilley, Who Ran Biden's Southern Firewall, Leaves Wilmington Without Comment

VARIETY

Marc-Anthony Bullock Becomes First Former Child Star to Lead a Major-Party Ticket

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

From 'Kid Mayor' to Presumptive Nominee: Inside Hollywood's Stunned, Thrilled, and Terrified Reaction

DEADLINE

Bullock Nomination Livestream Draws 31.4 Million, Topping His Own Announcement Record

PEOPLE

'The Girl With the Spreadsheet': Emma Bullock, 11, Gets a Shout-Out From President Biden

TAG

EXT. INTERSTATE 95 SOUTH — DELAWARE/MARYLAND LINE — NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 26, 2024 — 12:41 AM EDT

A black town car on the empty interstate. Cornelius in the back seat. He told the campaign he didn't need a flight. He wanted to drive. Eleven hours to Atlanta. He wanted the time.

The road unspools in the headlights. The DRIVER, an older man, has the radio on low. A gospel station out of Baltimore.

Cornelius holds his phone. He has been holding it since they crossed into Maryland.

He scrolls through his contacts. Past "ESTHER." Past "LORRAINE." Past "MOTHER." Past "NEIL" and "SIMONE."

To a name he added in 2013 and has never once used: "MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK."

He stares at it. His thumb hovers over the call button for a very long time.

On the radio, softly, a choir begins "Blessed Assurance." The same hymn from Sunday.

Cornelius presses the button.

The phone rings once.

Twice.

On the third ring, Cornelius ends the call before it connects. He sets the phone face-down on the seat beside him. Closes his eyes.

INT. SUNRISE HILL — MASTER BEDROOM — NIGHT

SUPER: 9:42 PM PDT

Marc and Esther in bed, both awake, staring at the ceiling, still processing. The house is quiet. The helicopters are gone.

On Marc's nightstand, his phone lights up. Silent mode. A notification:

INSERT — PHONE SCREEN: "MISSED CALL — CORNELIUS SMILLEY — 9:41 PM"

Marc sees it. He sits up very slowly. Stares at it.

ESTHER
What?

He turns the phone toward her. She reads it. Sits up too.

ESTHER
...He's never called you.

MARC
Never. Not once. Eleven years.

They look at each other. Marc's thumb moves toward "Call Back."

Esther puts her hand gently over his.

ESTHER
Not tonight.

MARC
He called.

ESTHER
He hung up. On the third ring. He called to see if he could. Let him have that, baby. He'll call again when he can stay on the line.

Marc looks at the screen a long moment. Then he sets the phone down on the nightstand, face-up. Lies back. Esther lies back too, her head on his chest.

MARC
Esther.

ESTHER
Mm.

MARC
I'm the presumptive nominee.

ESTHER
I know, baby.

MARC
Of a major party.

ESTHER
I know.

MARC
For President.

ESTHER
Marc. Go to sleep.

A long pause.

MARC
...Bet.

Esther laughs into his chest. He grins at the ceiling.

On the nightstand, the phone stays lit for a few more seconds: "MISSED CALL — CORNELIUS SMILLEY." Then the screen goes dark.

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER SEVEN

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 7

Timeline: Sun Mar 10, 2024, 11:02 AM EDT (DST began 2 AM) → Fri Apr 26, 2024, 12:41 AM EDT / Thu Apr 25, 9:42 PM PDT. **President Biden's Oval Office address: Thu Apr 25, 2024, 8:00 PM EDT (ends ~8:11 PM), exactly one year after his Apr 25, 2023 launch. Marc becomes the PRESUMPTIVE DEMOCRATIC NOMINEE.** Marc's livestream acceptance from the Sunrise Hill terrace: 6:20–6:27 PM PDT, 31.4M live viewers.

Ages: Mar 10: Esther 31 · Cornelius 65 · Odessa 95 · Lorraine 62 · Simone 36 · Neil 39. Apr 25: Marc 32 · Esther 31 · Emma & Victoria 11 (turn 12 May 10) · Lyric 10 (turned 10 Apr 20) · Amond 32 · Harmony 31 · Elxa 33 · Grace 30 (Apr 12) · Arianna 31 · Natasha 52 · Robert 55 · Victor 77 · Joan 76 (Apr 17) · Odessa 95 · Cornelius 65 · Lorraine 62 · Neil 40 (Mar 22) · Simone 36 · Patti 60 · Roy 66. Real people: Biden 81 · Trump 77 · Harris 59 · Obama 62 · Jeffries 53 · Schumer 73 · Clyburn 83 · Muir 50 · Stephanopoulos 63.

Real events depicted: Biden's State of the Union (Mar 7); Trump clinches the GOP nomination (Mar 12); Key Bridge collapse in Baltimore (Mar 26); total solar eclipse over Dallas (Apr 8, ~1:40 PM CDT totality); Trump hush-money trial begins (Apr 15); House passes the $95B Ukraine/Israel/Taiwan aid package (Sat Apr 20); SCOTUS immunity oral argument in Trump v. United States (Thu Apr 25); LBJ's Mar 31, 1968 withdrawal as precedent; Biden's 1972 Senate election at 29 and the Dec 1972 crash that killed his wife Neilia and daughter Naomi; Beau Biden's death (2015); Biden's "bridge" to a new generation (2020).

Our-world primary results (Mar 12–Apr 23): GA Bullock 50.4–47.1 (Mar 12; Cornelius loses his home state); MS Biden; WA Bullock; Mar 19: IL, OH, AZ, KS Bullock, FL Biden; LA Biden; MO Bullock; Apr 2: NY, WI, CT, RI Bullock, DE Biden; AK, HI, WY Bullock; **PA Bullock 50.2–48.3 (Apr 23, Biden's birth state).** Pledged delegates as of Apr 24 (est.): **Bullock ~1,718, Biden ~1,526** (lead ~192; Biden would need ~64% of the rest). Bullock has won 29 contests (including unsanctioned NH). Expected formal clinch: Tue May 14, 2024 (MD, NE, WV), with Puerto Rico (Apr 28) and Indiana (May 7) before it.

Our-world events: Esther speaks at Greater Mount Calvary (built 1923; Pastor Rev. Dr. Calvin Holloway, 70, fictional): "I love you, Daddy. I'm not on your side. But I love you." Cornelius arrives in Josiah's burgundy tie, sits in the third pew beside Odessa, turns his palm up, and Odessa takes his hand. "Blessed Assurance." Mar 9: Marc and Neil at Morehouse's Forbes Arena, while Cornelius introduces a Biden event in southwest Atlanta. Mar 12: Cornelius at Biden's Georgian Terrace watch party, leaving through the kitchen. Cornelius called Neil on his 40th birthday (Mar 22). Apr 8: Marc

and Roy Chapman at the eclipse in Dallas (Fair Park). Apr 20: Lyric's 10th birthday at 4:20 PM, a private party, wish "I wish he wins." The twins attend Paul Revere Middle School (in canon). Biden (via a senior aide): "Nobody wins a fight against their own kid. And nobody should." Biden's call to Marc: "Kid, you ran one hell of a race," a White House invitation next week, campaigning for Marc in PA and MI, and "tell the girl with the spreadsheet he kept one too, in 1972, on a legal pad." Marc tells Esther first, keeping her rule. **Cornelius tells Wes Thornton "Lose my number" and blocks him (8:19 PM EDT).** Cornelius drives home to Atlanta (11 hours) and calls Marc for the first time ever (9:41 PM PDT), hanging up on the third ring. Esther: "He'll call again when he can stay on the line." Amendment status: 231 House co-sponsors (38 Republicans); 290 votes needed in the House, 67 in the Senate. Clyburn will meet Marc in his South Carolina church. Fictional analysts: Rep. (Ret.) Diane Kastle (61, R-OH) and Dr. Malcolm Reese (55, Howard).

Looming event (in-world): the general election, Tue Nov 5, 2024, Bullock vs. Trump. Next: the age amendment, the running-mate pick, and the DNC in Chicago (Aug 19–22).